

WESTERN MUSIC

Shillong | MEGHALAYA

Shillong

One-man school of rock

A 60-year-old rock 'n roller inspires a generation of balladeers and bands in the North-East



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■ By Swagata Sen

In Shillong—the rock capital of the country—you can get lucky in a shared cab, those black and yellow Maruti 800s that dot the town like little miscoloured ladybirds. Seated next to you could be the legendary Lou Majaw with his trademark wild hair and the shortest of shorts as he goes to pick his daughter up from school or checks on his mother. Only when you pay a visit to his cottage, which he calls White House, do you see his musical genius. Over a glass of whisky to smoothen down the day's edges, in the faint light of a bulb that barely lets you see the posters of Bob Dylan and scores of musical instruments, Majaw breaks into song for his audience.

Somewhere in the small, smoke-filled room, whose walls are lined with clocks that are not meant to show the time, you are faced with a history that might not be of any interest to the rest of the world, but is one that matters to Shillong's musicians. So much so that they don't care about the big bucks that await them in city pubs struggling with mediocrity. "I pay my rent, and have food on my table," says Majaw, as if that is all that matters. It probably does. Coming from a poor family, Majaw worked as a daily-wage labourer in Kolkata before he began singing at Moulin Rouge and other Park Street pubs. As Kolkata waits for Majaw and Friends to descend from the hills and treat it to a feast of some of the world's greatest music, the musician lives his life regulated by Rs-8-a-ride share cabs, singing, "*I've known hunger since I was ten, Loneliness is my good friend, I've learnt to laugh when I feel sad, when I see good times turnin' bad.*"

At 60, Majaw has founded and been a member of many bands. For him, bands come and go. "I mean, you look at the Rolling Stones and you think a band should stick together. Sure, they are together. But that doesn't mean they don't bitch," he says. Majaw has been part of Indian bands such as Dynamite Boys, Vanguard, Blood and Thunder and Supersound Factory. In the 1970s, he formed his own band, The Great Society, DVDs and music CDs of which he still carries for people to buy. "I live music, baby," he says.

Majaw changed the future of Shillong's music when he organised a Dylan concert on the singer's birthday in 1972. It was through the concert that the whole of the North-East found its voice. True, rock 'n roll was a nasty word to most mothers in the '70s, one associated with drugs and alcohol. But music is what unites the people of Shillong now. About six bands from the city have a national presence, Snow White, of *U Rangdajied* fame, being the most prominent. Yet, they call Majaw, "a legend". Sadly, not a single pub in Shillong plays live music, a fact that riles Majaw. But he is hopeful. In his typical over-the-top manner, he says that even if a rose blooms in the desert, someone will get to know of it. As one of his lines goes, "*When life gets too real, Take some time to dream.*" He then closes his eyes to strum his favourite Dylan number.